PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #65 · ABUSE

“I have to keep this secret. Speaking up would only make everything worse.”

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Where it often comes from

Secrets often start as survival. Someone said telling would ruin the family, the church, or you. Or you learned that speaking made things worse. Silence can be wise when a person is not safe to tell. The lie says you must keep the secret forever, and that speaking up will only destroy everything. You are allowed to tell a safe person. You are allowed to tell only what you choose. Telling a counselor, a hotline, or the police is not betrayal. It is a way to get help. If you are not safe right now, call 911. You can also call the National Domestic Violence Hotline at 1-800-799-7233. If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453. A counselor can help you at a pace that is safe. You do not have to do this alone, or all at once.

What Scripture teaches

We are told to carry one another’s burdens, which cannot happen if the burden is locked away from every safe person. God is the God of all comfort. He is near the brokenhearted. People who follow Him are told to weep with those who weep. You can cast this fear on Him because He cares. None of this demands a public story. It does say that a secret kept from everyone is not the only faithful choice.

> *“Carry one another’s burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ”* (Galatians 6:2).

Also see

> “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our troubles, so that we can comfort those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves have received from God” (2 Corinthians 1:3–4).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Rejoice with those who rejoice; weep with those who weep” (Romans 12:15).

> “Cast all your anxiety on Him, because He cares for you” (1 Peter 5:7).

Common self-statements

- If I tell, everything will fall apart.
- I would be betraying the family or the church.
- No one can know.
- Speaking up would only make it worse for me.
- Good people keep this kind of thing quiet.
- God wants me to protect their reputation.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Deciding that any word will certainly ruin everything.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either the secret stays with everyone or you tell the world.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling panic at the thought of telling, and calling panic a command.
- Mind reading: Assuming every helper would make it worse.

Challenging questions

- Who told me this had to stay a secret, and did they have something to protect?
- Is there one person whose job is to help, not to guard the secret?
- What am I afraid will happen, and what might happen if I stay silent?
- Do I have to tell everything in order to get help?
- What would I want a friend to do with a secret like this?
- What number can I call if I am not safe today?

Truth summary

> I do not have to keep this secret from every safe person. I can tell a counselor or a helper, say only what I choose, and ask for protection.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

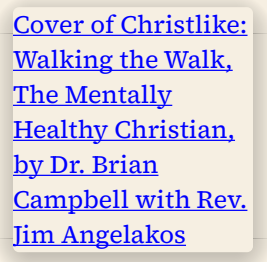
- Help
- Trust
- Fear
- Loneliness
- Thinking, Healthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Prayer
- Suffering

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



Cover of Christlike: Walking the Walk, The Mentally Healthy Christian, by Dr. Brian Campbell with Rev. Jim Angelakos

From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Speak O Lord — Keith and Kristyn Getty
You can speak a little. A secret does not have to be your only safety.

Even If — MercyMe
You can bring a hard truth to God even if you are not ready to tell a person.

Forgiveness — Matthew West
The song is about releasing what someone did, not about keeping their secret for them.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
God's faithfulness does not depend on your silence.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I have to keep this secret. Speaking up would only make everything worse."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to keep this secret. Speaking up would only make everything worse." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who told me this had to stay a secret, and did they have something to protect?
- ☐ Is there one person whose job is to help, not to guard the secret?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen, and what might happen if I stay silent?
- ☐ Do I have to tell everything in order to get help?
- ☐ What would I want a friend to do with a secret like this?
- ☐ What number can I call if I am not safe today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I do not have to keep this secret from every safe person. I can tell a counselor or a helper, say only what I choose, and ask for protection.
- ☐ Silence kept me going, and it does not have to last forever.
- ☐ I choose who hears me.
- ☐ Telling a safe helper is not destroying everything.
- ☐ God already knows, and He is not shocked.
- ☐ I can stop if a conversation stops feeling safe.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Galatians 6:2
  "Carry one another's burdens, and in this way you will fulfill the law of Christ."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 1:3–4
  "Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, the Father of compassion and the God of all comfort, who comforts us in all our troubles, so that we can comfort those in any trouble with the comfort we ourselves have received from God."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."

A verse I found myself:

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the secret felt mandatory: Each day, write down one moment when speaking up felt like it would destroy everything. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 6:2 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can let one safe person help carry this. I do not have to keep it alone.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Help" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone. If you are not safe right now, call 911 or 1-800-799-7233.

- [ ] Tell one professional first, a counselor or 1-800-799-7233, not the person who hurt you. You can say as little as "I am not safe" or "I need help with abuse."
- [ ] Write what you are willing to say in one sentence, with no graphic detail. You do not have to share it today.
- [ ] Name who must not be the first hearer. The person who hurt you does not get to control the secret.
- [ ] If a child is being hurt, call Childhelp at 1-800-422-4453 or 911. You do not have to investigate it yourself.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to keep this secret. Speaking up would only make everything worse.": _____ %

My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A step out of total silence
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to keep this secret. Speaking up would only make everything worse~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have carried this secret because I was afraid speaking would ruin everything. You already know. Give me one safe helper, and the courage to tell only what I choose. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.